Chapter 13 – India is “Rediscovered” by Portugal

Though India and the Roman Empire had been in contact as early as 30 BCE, the fall of the latter civilization meant that the European world shrank significantly in terms of worldview. The Dark Ages were set in motion, and until the Renaissance of the 14th to 17th centuries, contact between Europe and India was all but lost. For Portugal, recovering its strength and wealth was a feat dedicated to shipbuilding and exploration. In 1498, Vasco da Gama and his crew arrived near modern Calicut and once more connected the Western world to that of India. They were the first post-Greco-Roman European nation to establish a link with India via the Malabar Coast and King Zamorin of Calicut.

Though Portugal beat the rest of Europe to India, it was just one more foreign power among many Asian and Middle Eastern nations already trading with the various empires and kingdoms of pre-Modern India. King Zamorin was friendly to exotic nations and he allowed da Gama to fill his ship with the same aromatic spices that were always in demand of his people. Upon returning to Portugal, the explorer found that these goods were valued at more than sixty times the cost of the entire expedition to India. Once such goods were discovered, there was no doubt about whether more ships would be sent. Over the next years, Portuguese merchants came in droves to Calicut. Their motives were generally selfish, which led them into multiple skirmishes with the local culture and other expatriate traders.

The major source of conflict between Indian nationals and the Portuguese settlers was religion. Portugal was a strictly Catholic country, and India was a land of many gods. The 100 million people who called the subcontinent home were mainly Muslim and Hindu, with significant populations of Jains and Buddhists. Though the Catholic Church was not impressed by any of these belief systems, it took the most offense to Islam which shared an ancient belief in the prophecies of the angel Gabriel. Since the Mughals were faithful to the Islamic church, Portugal was constantly at odds with the Mughal rulers and administrators of the realm; even following several peace treaties and alliances with Indian leaders, Vasco da Gama and his compatriots essentially fought their way up the coast, one moment making alliances and the next breaking them. It was a treacherous and chaotic time